

Figure 15: A. Sundara Sastri

Five days later, Wynch wrote a rather lengthy demi-official letter to the chief secretary, based, this time, on a discussion with A. Sundara Sastri, government pleader and ‘a leading director’ of SSNCo (Figure 15). In Wynch’s view, Sundara Sastri had ‘a clearer grasp of the situation’ who saw ‘the almost hopelessness’ of the situation.[59] Apparently, he confessed that some of the directors were in favour of liquidation. He shared the balance sheet of the company with Wynch, who showed it to Eric Chapman. Chapman did not believe the figures. For instance, Chapman said that the *Miranda*, bought for Rs 11,000, was shown with a book value of Rs 24,784 by adding the working expenses of the charter for the *Despatch*, another launch. Similarly, the repairs and fitting out to the *Gallia* and the *Lawoe* had been added to its capital value without charging any depreciation. Chapman estimated that SSNCo made a monthly loss of Rs 25,000 and that the gross profit returned covered neither the water and coal expenses nor the port and light dues. Moreover, one Felenege Reid and Company had got a decree from the Supreme Court of Colombo for impounding the *Lawoe* for an unpaid bill of Rs 1,700, and it could be released only after some settlement